

The Great Law of Peace

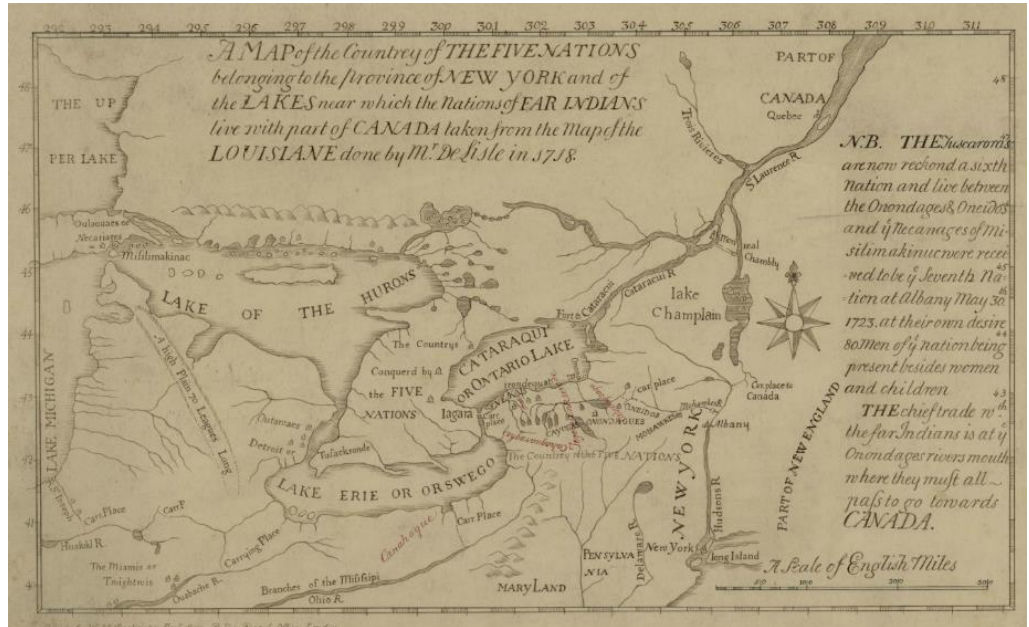
The Iroquois Confederacy was a union of the Seneca, Cayuga, Onondaga, Oneida, and Mohawk tribes. All were Iroquoian-speaking tribes in the Eastern Woodlands region of North America. They are also known as the Haudenosaunee (People of the Longhouse) or the 5 Nations, until the Tuscarora people joined in 1722. They then became known as the Six Nations.

According to Iroquois legend, around the year 1500, a Mohawk named Dekanawida convinced the nations to unite to establish peace and to protect “life, property, and liberty.” Dekanawidah, (also known as the Great Peacemaker) and his spokesman Hiawatha created a constitution known as the Great Law of Peace

Their Great Law of Peace was not written, however. It was only shared orally and through strings of wampum shell beads. Therefore, the exact date of its origination is unknown. Some scholars agree to a date of 1451. However, Seneca’s oral history mentions that the constitution was adopted shortly after a total eclipse of the sun. Scholarship indicates that such an eclipse occurred on August 13, 1142.

Either date makes the Great Law of Peace the oldest living constitution. It still governs the Iroquois today and gives member peoples equal voice in the nations’ affairs.

The Great Law of Peace includes 117 laws and customs governing all aspects of life. An excerpt from the constitution is included below.



Tree of Great Peace

1. I am Dekanawida and with the Five Nations’ Confederate Lords I plant the Tree of the Great Peace. I plant it in your territory, Tadodaho*, and the Onondaga Nation, in the territory of you who are Firekeepers.

I name the tree the Tree of the Great Long Leaves. Under the shade of this Tree of the Great Peace we spread the soft white feathery down of the globe thistle as seats for you, Tadodaho, and your cousin Lords.

We place you upon those seats, spread soft with the feathery down of the globe thistle, there beneath the shade of the spreading branches of the Tree of Peace. There shall you sit and watch the Council Fire of the Confederacy of the Five Nations, and all the affairs of the Five Nations shall be transacted at this place before you, Tadodaho, and your cousin Lords, by the Confederate Lords of the Five Nations.

2. Roots have spread out from the Tree of the Great Peace, one to the north, one to the east, one to the south, and one to the west. The name of these roots is The Great White Roots and their nature is Peace and Strength.

* Tadodaho was the sachem or paramount chief of the Onondaga nation.

If any man or any nation outside the Five Nations shall obey the laws of the Great Peace and make known their disposition to the Lords of the Confederacy, they may trace the Roots to the Tree and if their minds are clean and they are obedient and promise to obey the wishes of the Confederate Council, they shall be welcomed to take shelter beneath the Tree of the Long Leaves.

We place at the top of the Tree of the Long Leaves an Eagle who is able to see afar. If he sees in the distance any evil approaching or any danger threatening, he will at once warn the people of the Confederacy.

Leaders

26. The Lords of the Confederacy of the Five Nations shall be mentors of the people for all time. The thickness of their skin shall be seven spans—which is to say that they shall be proof against anger, offensive actions, and criticism. Their hearts shall be full of peace and goodwill and their minds filled with a yearning for the welfare of the people of the Confederacy. With endless patience they shall carry out their duty and their firmness shall be tempered with a tenderness for their people. Neither anger nor fury shall find lodgment in their minds and all their words and actions shall be marked by calm deliberation.

29. All Lords of the Five Nations Confederacy must be honest in all things. They must not idle or gossip, but be men possessing those honorable qualities that make true royaneh (noble). It shall be a serious wrong for anyone to lead a Lord into trivial affairs, for the people must ever hold their Lords high in estimation out of respect to their honorable positions.

Clans

46. The lineal descent of the people of the Five Nations shall run in the female line. Women shall be considered the progenitors of the Nation. They shall own the land and the soil. Men and women shall follow the status of the mother.

Symbols

59. Five arrows shall be bound together very strong and each arrow shall represent one nation. As the five arrows are strongly bound this shall symbolize the complete union of the nations. Thus, are the Five Nations united completely and enfolded together, united into one head, one body, and one mind. Therefore, they shall labor, legislate, and council together for the interest of future generations.

War and Peace

67. I, Dekanawida, and the Union Lords, now uproot the tallest pine tree and into the cavity thereby made we cast all weapons of war. Into the depths of the earth, down into the deep underearth currents of water flowing to unknown regions we cast all the weapons of strife. We bury them from sight, and we plant again the tree. Thus, shall the Great Peace be established and hostilities shall no longer be known between the Five Nations but peace to the United People.

Rights of the People

95. Whenever a specially important matter or a great emergency is presented before the Confederate Council and the nature of the matter affects the entire body of the Five Nations, threatening their utter ruin, then the Lords of the Confederacy must submit the matter to the decision of their people and the decision of the people shall affect the decision of the Confederate Council. This decision shall be a confirmation of the voice of the people.

Name _____

The Great Law of Peace

Directions: After reading the Iroquois constitution, answer the following questions in complete sentences.

1. What was the Great Tree of Peace and what did it symbolize?
2. What was the purpose of the Great Law of Peace?
3. What characteristics did the Iroquois look for in their leaders?
4. How would you describe the status of women in the Iroquois Confederacy?
5. What was the symbolism of the Five arrows?
6. Why did Dekanawida uproot the tallest pine tree?
7. In what way was the Great Law of Peace democratic?

The Great Law of Peace

Directions: Teachers, you can access an editable [Google Doc version of this worksheet by clicking here.](#)

1. What was the Great Tree of Peace and what did it symbolize?

The tree was planted in the Onondaga Nation and would be the location of the Council Fire of the Confederacy of the Five Nations. It was also a symbol of their union together, with the roots going deep into the ground.

2. What was the purpose of the Great Law of Peace?

Open to many possible student responses. However, they should likely note that the 5 tribes were coming together for peace and likely wanted some form agreement on what that would mean and look like for the future.

3. What characteristics did the Iroquois look for in their leaders?

Their hearts shall be full of peace and goodwill and their minds filled with a yearning for the welfare of the people of the Confederacy. With endless patience they shall carry out their duty and their firmness shall be tempered with a tenderness for their people. Neither anger nor fury shall find lodgment in their minds and all their words and actions shall be marked by calm deliberation.

4. How would you describe the status of women in the Iroquois Confederacy?

Women appear to have had a high status in society, especially compared to women in colonial society at the time. Women were considered the progenitors of the Nation and “own the land and the soil.”

5. What was the symbolism of the Five arrows?

The five arrows symbolized the 5 nations coming together. Like a fascia or bundle of sticks that is stronger when tied together, the 5 arrows show that the 5 nations are stronger together.

6. Why did Dekanawida uproot the tallest pine tree?

This was a symbolic act in which their weapons of war were buried within the tree to show that they would no longer need them because they were all now at peace.

7. In what way was the Great Law of Peace democratic?

It was very democratic. Whenever an important matter was presented before the Council, Lords were required to bring it back to their people. The decision of the people would affect the decision of the Confederate Council.